

Navigating careers in the digital age: the influence of AI-powered social media platforms on Chinese graduate students' career decision-making

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Abstract. This article investigates the role of AI-powered social media platforms in shaping the career decision-making processes of graduate students in China. Drawing upon qualitative data from 20 semi-structured interviews, it explores how user-generated content (UGC), cultural capital, and social reproduction intersect in influencing career perceptions and choices in the context of China's rapidly digitalizing society. The findings reveal that platforms such as Douyin, Weibo, and Xiaohongshu serve not only as sources of career information but also as spaces where peer narratives, curated success stories, and algorithmic visibility shape graduate students' aspirations and anxieties. Moreover, AI algorithms significantly impact students' career aspirations through UGC which are mediated by cultural capital and social reproduction. Digital inequality emerges from algorithmic biases, hence exacerbating social reproduction. This study contributes to the literature on AI-powered digital media and youth transitions by contextualizing career choice in China's unique sociocultural landscape. It highlights the importance of critical digital literacy, inclusive AI, and ethical algorithm design to support equitable career outcomes.

1 Introduction

AI-driven social media platforms significantly shape career decisions among Chinese graduate students. Algorithmically curated UGC on platforms like Douyin, Weibo, and Xiaohongshu influences students' aspirations by selectively amplifying narratives of success. Using Bourdieu's theories of cultural capital and social reproduction, this research examines how socio-cultural backgrounds mediate students' engagement with AI-filtered digital content, framing digital inequality as both caused and potentially remedied by AI systems.

For Chinese graduate students—individuals at a critical juncture between higher education and employment—career decision-making is increasingly mediated through digital content. These students, many of whom are “digital natives,” actively engage with algorithm-driven, user-generated content (UGC) that informs, inspires, or sometimes pressures them into certain career trajectories. While social media platforms offer valuable insights into labour markets, networking strategies, and peer experiences, they also present curated portrayals of success that may distort students' expectations and exacerbate anxieties. As a result, students' engagement with these platforms is not merely informational but deeply relational and affective.

Despite growing interest in the sociocultural effects of AI-powered digital platforms, limited research has specifically examined the intersection of social media and career decision-making among graduate students in

China. Existing scholarship tends to focus on general youth populations, Western contexts, or the economic functions of digital platforms in job matching. What remains underexplored is how AI-powered social media operates as a career-influencing infrastructure embedded in a context where traditional values (e.g., Confucian ideals of stability and family honour) co-exist with globalized notions of success and self-fulfillment. Addressing this gap is especially important given that Chinese graduate students represent a socially significant cohort—both as knowledge workers of the future and as cultural intermediaries navigating between digital modernity and entrenched structural hierarchies.

This study therefore investigates: To what extent do AI-powered social media platforms influence the career choices of Chinese graduate students? The research is guided by two main objectives: (1) to explore how graduate students engage with career-related content on social media, and (2) to analyze how cultural capital and social reproduction mediate the influence of this content on career decision-making.

2 Literature review

Social media, increasingly governed by AI algorithms, profoundly impacts career exploration among Chinese youth, with AI-driven visibility disproportionately benefiting privileged users. User-generated career narratives are algorithmically amplified, often creating unrealistic career expectations. Cultural capital critically mediates users' abilities to evaluate AI-curated content,

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reinforcing inequalities rooted in social reproduction. Highlighting digital inequality emphasizes the need for ethical and inclusive AI practices to ensure equitable career opportunities.

2.1 Social media and career navigation in China

Social media platforms have fundamentally reshaped how individuals' access, process, and act upon information relevant to their personal and professional lives. In the context of career development, digital platforms now serve as both information repositories and interactive spaces where aspirational norms are formed and contested. This shift is particularly salient in China, which hosts the world's largest population of internet users and some of the most dynamic platform ecologies globally.

Among Chinese youth, especially university students, social media usage is nearly universal. Over 99% of university students report daily engagement with social platforms [1], and nearly 75% of China's total population are social media users [2]. Platforms such as Douyin (TikTok's Chinese counterpart), Weibo, and Xiaohongshu (Red) are not only popular for entertainment but also increasingly used for career-related purposes including job search, resume preparation, and industry exploration [3].

However, this content is not neutral. It is curated through algorithmic filtering and shaped by platform logics that prioritize visibility, emotional engagement, and profitability [4]. As such, career representations may become idealized or distorted, intensifying the pressure to conform to narrow definitions of success. In the Chinese context, where socio-economic mobility is tightly linked to education and employment outcomes, this phenomenon takes on particular significance for graduate students navigating a competitive labour market.

User-generated content (UGC) is central to the participatory affordances of social media and plays a pivotal role in how young people conceptualize and pursue career options. UGC includes a range of formats—blogs, vlogs, posts, comments, and testimonials—produced by peers, influencers, or professionals. Unlike institutional career guidance, UGC tends to be personal, experience-based, and emotionally resonant, making it especially impactful in shaping users' attitudes, values, and aspirations [5,6].

However, the credibility and completeness of UGC are variable. As May et al. argue, content on social media is highly filtered—both by algorithms and by users' own self-presentation strategies [7]. Success stories are often overrepresented, while failure, uncertainty, or dissatisfaction may be omitted, creating an illusory career optimism. This curation can shape students' imagined futures in problematic ways, particularly when social media becomes the dominant lens through which career options are evaluated.

Moreover, the influence of UGC is not uniform. Unay-Gailhard and Brennen, studying European youth in agriculture, found that digital narratives could reframe previously unattractive careers (e.g., farming) as innovative and meaningful [8]. Yet, this reframing

was mediated by users' access to digital tools, prior experiences, and socio-cultural backgrounds. Similar dynamics are likely at play in China, but have received insufficient scholarly attention, especially among graduate students.

2.2 Cultural capital and social reproduction in the digital age

While UGC presents an image of democratized information access, engagement with career content is profoundly shaped by social position, educational background, and family expectations. These dynamics are well captured by Bourdieu's theory of cultural capital and the related concept of social reproduction.

Embodied cultural capital, defined as the internalized dispositions and competencies acquired through upbringing and education, significantly influences how individuals interpret and apply career-related information. For instance, students with elite educational backgrounds may be more adept at critically assessing social media content, networking with professionals, or strategically navigating platform affordances. Conversely, those from less privileged backgrounds may struggle to distinguish between credible information and superficial hype, potentially reinforcing existing disadvantages [9].

In the Chinese context, cultural capital is deeply intertwined with Confucian values such as respect for authority, educational achievement, and prioritization of collective over individual goals [10,11]. These values shape not only career preferences (e.g., preference for government or academic jobs) but also how social media content is filtered and interpreted by users and their families. Family expectations, for example, may lead students to selectively seek or avoid certain types of career content, even when the platform offers diverse possibilities.

Social reproduction, meanwhile, refers to the mechanisms by which privileged groups maintain their status across generations. One of the key processes is the transmission of cultural capital that aligns with institutional criteria of success. In digital contexts, this transmission is extended through social media: students from affluent families often have early exposure to globalized values, professional norms, and influential networks that help them maximize social media for career advantage [12]. Social platforms thus become a site where inequalities are not only reflected but potentially amplified.

Binder et al. illustrate this in their study of elite university graduates, showing how institutional norms and peer environments guide students toward "prestigious" career paths [13]. Similarly, Power et al. demonstrate that national education systems cultivate specific career ideologies [14]. Yet, these studies are predominantly Euro-American in focus. There remains a need to investigate how these dynamics unfold in East Asian contexts, where family, hierarchy, and collectivism exert powerful influences on youth trajectories.

Taking together, this literature review reveals several gaps. While social media's role in shaping career

imaginaries is well recognized, its intersection with socio-cultural factors like cultural capital and social reproduction remains under-theorized, particularly in the Chinese context. Furthermore, the role of UGC as a relational and class-mediated form of informal career guidance demands deeper investigation. This study contributes by integrating these theoretical strands through an empirical examination of how graduate students in China engage with career content on social media platforms—how they are inspired, constrained, and positioned within broader structures of inequality.

3 Methodology

3.1 Research design

This study adopts a qualitative research design using semi-structured interviews captured graduate students' experiences with AI-powered social media content. A qualitative approach is particularly appropriate for investigating complex social phenomena that are shaped by subjective meanings, embodied experiences, and socio-cultural context [15]. Twenty diverse participants (gender-balanced and geographically varied) provided insights into their interactions with career-related content, mediated by cultural capital and social reproduction. Data analysis employed an immersion-crystallization approach to identify themes connecting AI systems, cultural capital, and career outcomes.

3.2 Participant sampling

Participants were selected through a combination of purposive sampling and snowball sampling; two techniques widely used in qualitative research to identify information-rich cases [16,17]. In this research, ten participants are chosen at first based on the criteria (Chinese residents under the age of 27, active social media platform users, graduate students). This initial group was asked to recommend peers who met the same criteria, allowing for the recruitment of an additional 10 participants through snowball sampling.

The final sample consisted of 20 participants (10 male, 10 female), representing diverse educational institutions (including elite and non-elite universities), family socioeconomic backgrounds, and regions (coastal, inland, urban, and rural). This demographic diversity is essential for investigating how variations in cultural capital and access to resources shape digital engagement.

3.3 Data collection

Data were collected through semi-structured interviews conducted in Mandarin Chinese, each lasting between 30 and 45 minutes. Interviews were conducted online (via Zoom or Tencent Meeting) to accommodate geographic dispersion and pandemic-related constraints. All interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim before being translated into English for analysis.

Participants were encouraged to reflect on specific examples, such as posts or videos that had shaped their thinking. The interviews also proved how participants' background (e.g., parents' occupation, type of university attended) influenced their engagement with career-related content. All identifiable information was anonymized, and ethical approval was obtained from the researcher's institution prior to data collection.

3.4 Data analysis

The data were analyzed using the immersion-crystallization approach [18], an iterative qualitative method that involves cycles of deep reading, reflection, and thematic emergence. This method was chosen for its ability to surface both latent patterns and context-specific insights, allowing for a nuanced interpretation of how social media and cultural structures interact in shaping career decisions.

4 Findings

4.1 Interaction with career AI-powered content on social media

Several key findings emerged regarding how Chinese graduate students engage with AI-powered social media content and the influence it has on their career decision-making processes. AI algorithms significantly shape the visibility and perceived credibility of career-related content. While students actively engage with algorithmically curated career narratives, excessive reliance can lead to confusion and anxiety due to biased filtering and idealized portrayals, highlighting the necessity for critical digital literacy. Not all students are equally equipped with such digital literacy, however, indicating an underlying digital inequality in their ability to critically assess algorithm-driven career content. Participants identify social media use as an essential part of their daily routine. One participant stated, "I often spend about two hours per day on social media, primarily on Red and Douyin. These platforms are where I get the majority of my knowledge, whether it's about the newest developments in my field of interest or general tips on how to be competitive in the job market." This comment demonstrates how social media platforms are more than just sources of entertainment—they are important tools for staying informed and making strategic career decisions. Notably, this heavy reliance presupposes reliable access to smartphones and high-speed internet—resources not uniformly available to all students. Thus, even within a digitally-savvy group, unequal access to technology can translate into disparities in who can fully leverage social media for career planning, which suggests an access-based dimension of digital inequality.

Particularly in this context, UGC is influential in shaping participants' career aspirations. Many participants acknowledge that they were attracted to content created by professionals and peers who shared their advice, success stories and experiences. For example, a participant shared that "I follow several

accounts on Douyin where people share their job search experiences and how they prepared for interviews. I actually took notes of them and applied them into my own job search process.” The influence of social media is found to extend beyond passively receiving information while analyzing the data. Participants actively engage with the content by sharing and commenting on it. This active participation allows them to feel more connected to the community they want to be a part of. However, there are also some challenges on overly rely on social media for developing career decisions. Some students find it confused because there is a huge amount of career information appearing on social media platforms when they search online. And it is particularly difficult to figure out which piece of information is credible, and which one is not. This indicates that those lacking the skills to filter and verify online information are more likely to feel overwhelmed by the mass of content. Unequal digital competencies can thus lead to unequal outcomes in career decision-making, as some students benefit far more from AI-mediated guidance than others.

Moreover, social media platforms’ role in shaping perceptions of success and failure is evident in the way participants compare themselves to peers. Several participants mentioned that they feel huge pressure to achieve similar achievement to those (of similar age) they see online. One participant commented that “When I scroll down my screen and see people my age already made so much money and bought their own car and houses by live streaming, it makes me feel really really nervous and anxious. I feel like I need to catch up and try live streaming for a living, but that kind of thought kinda drag me off my original plan.” This indicates a complex dynamic in which career decisions are influenced by social media, but it also generates strong emotional reactions that can influence those decisions in other ways.

These findings support Escoffery’s research by stating that UGC does impact the process of decision making [19]. Comparing this with Unay-Gailhard and Brennen’s work, the findings both show a positive effect of digital tools on career choices [8]; however, this study considers downsides of UGC (can bring negative emotions to users) to fill a gap. In addition, in comparison to Kara’s study [20], this research did not consider potential impact of the entertainment attributes of social media platforms may have on students’ use of social media platforms to find jobs.

4.2 Cultural capital and its mediation of AI-powered social media engagement

Cultural capital significantly influences students’ ability to critically engage with AI-curated content. Family expectations and educational backgrounds shape how effectively students navigate AI-driven information, empowering those with higher cultural capital and limiting those from less privileged backgrounds, thereby reinforcing digital inequalities. In practice, these digital inequalities manifest through differential access to technology and skills.

Several participants stated that their career choices are influenced largely by their parents’ expectations and values. One participant said, “My parents always say that they wish me to be a teacher or work in the government in the future because these are iron rice bowl (lifelong) jobs. When I look for career-related content, those kinds of jobs are the ones I pay more attention to.” This illustrates how deeply rooted family values and expectations influence students’ interactions with online content as well as their professional goals. It makes students more likely to seek out and trust information that aligns with their families’ values. Educational experiences have also emerged as an important factor influencing students’ use of social media for career decisions. A participant who attended a higher-tier university felt more confident in pursuing a prestigious career: “I was fortunate to attend a top university where the atmosphere leads me to pursue a better career. I think it has become a norm in our school to get a prestigious job, especially when my mates are all looking for that kind of job. And they often share articles and posts about those jobs in our group chat.” The environment of top universities provides students with a setting that encourages pursuing high-status careers, which is a direct reflection of the cultural capital these students have gained through education. It shapes students’ career decisions by creating a micro-society around campus that follows certain norms. Comparing the findings of this section to prior research, they align with Hart’s conclusion that cultural capital comprises a mix of factors affecting a person’s career goals [21]. This study’s findings also show that the levels of cultural capital among the 20 participants differ due to their varied backgrounds, and this difference results in different future career choices and distinct ways of engaging with social media platforms. This supports Bourdieu’s argument that cultural capital is unequally distributed, as individuals accumulate it in distinct ways. Furthermore, in comparison to Power et al.’s research [14], both studies identify cultural capital as a key influence on students’ career choices. Besides corroborating existing research, this study fills a gap by analyzing how cultural capital can have negative impacts—specifically, how it may narrow down potential career paths for those who lack it—thereby linking back to the issue of digital inequality in the context of AI-mediated career exploration.

4.3 Social reproduction and the reinforcement of social hierarchies

The third finding section indicates that the Social Reproduction Amplified by Algorithmic Bias AI-driven social media perpetuates existing social hierarchies through biased content recommendations favouring privileged backgrounds. Students with higher cultural capital leverage algorithmic visibility to reinforce professional advantages, while others experience heightened aspirations but face structural barriers. In this way, digital inequality functions as both a cause and an outcome of the process. It creates the initial gaps in access and literacy limit one’s engagement with AI-mediated content, and the platforms’ biased

reinforcement of user patterns further widens those gaps.

Some participants indicate that their use of social media platforms often reinforces their existing cultural and social capital, which leads to perpetuating existing hierarchies. “I followed and added some high-profile figures on Weibo and WeChat. Engaging with their contents not only helps me stay ahead in my field but is also a sign of being connected and informed.” This shows participation with elite networks on social media platforms strengthens participation’s social status and they can use these connections to improve their professional image and get more opportunities.

Moreover, findings show that social media platforms can perpetuate social hierarchies by prioritizing and promoting certain contents to users. Participants from wealthier families noted that they were frequently exposed to and engaged with content that aligns with elite values such as prestigious careers and exclusive educational opportunities.

The findings of this section align with Binder et al.’s study findings, they agree that students with prestigious backgrounds tend to maintain their social status whether such thoughts are intentional or established through an external environment [13]. This is evident through the way they engage with social media platforms. Such findings also support Bourdieu’s argument that cultural capitals accumulated by parents are passed on to their offsprings to consolidate their social hierarchy [18]. These findings provide additional insights that social media platforms themselves may be a catalyst in perpetuating social hierarchy, because social media platforms push information based on user’s preferences [11], and in other words, algorithmic curation on these platforms can make privileged individuals even more privileged in terms of career information and opportunities, exacerbating digital inequality.

5 Conclusion

The findings imply that AI-powered social media systems deeply influence Chinese graduate students’ career decision-making. Algorithmic biases amplify digital inequalities mediated by cultural capital and social reproduction. In this dynamic, digital inequality emerges as both a precursor and a product of AI-mediated career exploration: students with limited digital access or literacy are initially less able to benefit from online career resources, and subsequently, the algorithmic amplification of certain content further widens these disparities. Addressing these issues requires integrating critical digital literacy into education, promoting ethical and inclusive AI designs, and expanding diverse success narratives. These strategies align with broader themes of AI ethics, educational quality, and sustainability in digital societies.

In summary, this research underscores that extensive use of AI-powered social media platforms is reshaping how Chinese graduate students obtain career-related information and make career choices. It also highlights the importance of cultural capital in influencing

students’ use of social media and their career decision-making processes. The evidence leads to the conclusion that AI-powered social media platforms have a significant influence on Chinese graduate students’ career choices, and that cultural capital and social reproduction play important roles in shaping those choices and the ways students engage with social media content – often through the lens of underlying digital inequalities. To support more equitable career outcomes in the digital age, stakeholders in higher education and policy will need to address these digital divides. Interventions such as inclusive digital education programs and targeted training in digital literacy can help level the playing field so that all students, regardless of background, are empowered to navigate AI-mediated career information critically and effectively.

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